

Snails: Body Parts, Needs, and Dangers

K-2 Science Lesson Plan

Grades	K-2 (ages 5-8)	Time	48 minutes, one session
Unit	Animal Needs and Body Parts	Standards	NGSS K-LS1-1, 1-LS1-1 (related)
Format	Teacher-led, small groups	Materials	Live snails, pictures as backup

Overview

A hands-on K-2 science lesson with live snails. Children learn a snail's body parts, how it moves, what it needs to live, and what dangers it faces, then record their own observation. Includes an optional grade 2 life-cycle extension for a separate day.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the lesson, children can:

- 1. Name a snail's body parts.** Point to and name a snail's shell, foot, tentacles/eyes, and mouth on a picture or live snail.
- 2. Explain what a snail needs.** Name at least 2 things a snail needs to live: food (leaves), water or damp air, and shelter.
- 3. Describe how a snail moves.** Tell how a snail glides on its one foot using slime.
- 4. Name dangers snails face.** Say at least 2 dangers snails face, such as birds and other animals that eat them, drying out in hot sun, salt, garden sprays, or being stepped on.
- 5. Record an observation.** Draw a snail and label at least one body part or write or dictate one thing observed.

Materials

- Empty snail shell and a cloth bag
- Chart paper and markers ("I notice / I wonder" chart)
- Large labeled snail poster; small unlabeled snail pictures (1 per pair)
- Live garden snails (1 per small group), clear plastic sheet or lid, damp plates
- Short snail video (backup)
- Paper and a cup of water (dry vs. wet hands)
- Needs / doesn't-need picture cards (1 set per group)
- Clear tank with air holes, damp soil, rock or bark, lettuce or cucumber, spray bottle
- Danger picture cards: bird, beetle, frog, hot sun, salt shaker, spray bottle, shoe
- Magnifiers, crayons, journal pages with sentence frames
- Snail photo cards for any child who prefers not to be near a snail
- Soap and water for handwashing

Safety and Animal Care

- Check school rules on classroom animals and any allergies before the lesson.
- Use local garden snails. Handle gently with wet hands and keep them damp.
- Never put salt on a live snail. Use pictures to teach that danger.

- Everyone washes hands with soap after touching snails or soil.
- Return snails to the tank or to the place outside where they were found.

Lesson at a Glance

Min	Section	Outcome
5	Hook: Mystery Shell	1 Body parts
8	Meet the Snail: Body Parts	1 Body parts
7	How Snails Move	3 Movement
8	What Snails Need	2 Needs
7	Snail Dangers	4 Dangers
8	Scientist Observation Journal	5 Observation
5	Wrap-Up and Quick Check	1 Body parts, 2 Needs, 3 Movement, 4 Dangers
48	Total	

Lesson Steps

1. Hook: Mystery Shell (5 min)

Say to children	Reach into the bag and feel the mystery object. Don't peek! What does it feel like? Who do you think lived inside it? Tell us one thing you notice and one thing you wonder.
Teacher notes	Materials: empty snail shell in a cloth bag, chart paper. Pass the bag around the circle. After guesses, reveal the shell. Make a two-column chart: 'I notice' and 'I wonder'. Keep the chart up to return to at the end.

2. Meet the Snail: Body Parts (8 min)

Say to children	Let's meet the snail! Find the shell, the foot, the tentacles, and the mouth. Play 'Snail Says': touch your shell (your back), wiggle your tentacles (your fingers on your head), wave your foot. Then point to each part on your partner's picture and say its name.
Teacher notes	Materials: large labeled snail poster, small unlabeled snail pictures (one per pair). Teach each part with its job. Play 'Snail Says' for 2 minutes. Pairs take turns pointing and naming. Listen in for who is unsure.

3. How Snails Move (7 min)

Say to children	Look under the snail. What do you see on its foot? Now be a snail: lie on your tummy and glide very slowly. Next, rub your dry hand on paper, then your wet hand. Which one slides better? Why do you think snails make slime?
Teacher notes	Materials: live snail on a clear plastic sheet or lid, held up so children see the foot from underneath; short video as backup; paper and a cup of water. Handle snails gently with wet hands. Keep the snail damp.

4. What Snails Need (8 min)

Say to children	Sort the picture cards. Does a snail need it, or not? Put leaves, water drops, and a damp hiding place in the 'needs' pile. Put toys, candy, and TV in the 'doesn't need' pile. Then help build our snail home and say what each thing is for.
Teacher notes	Materials: needs/doesn't-need picture cards (one set per small group), clear tank with air holes, damp soil, a rock or bark for shelter, lettuce or cucumber, spray bottle. Groups sort for 4 minutes, then build the class snail home together, naming each need as it goes in.

5. Snail Dangers (7 min)

Say to children	Look at each picture. How could this hurt a snail? What does a snail do to stay safe? What is one thing you can do to help snails?
Teacher notes	Materials: danger picture cards (bird, beetle, frog, hot sun, salt shaker, spray bottle, shoe). Do not demonstrate salt on a live snail. Collect 'ways to help' on the chart.

6. Scientist Observation Journal (8 min)

Say to children	You are a scientist! Look closely at the snail with your magnifier. Draw what you see. Label one part, like 'shell' or 'foot'. Then finish a sentence: 'I see the snail's ____.' or 'The snail is ____.'
Teacher notes	Materials: journal page with a drawing box and sentence frames, magnifiers, crayons, 1 live snail per small group on a damp plate, photo cards for any child who prefers not to be near a snail. Write dictated sentences for children who need it and mark them 'dictated'. Collect pages.

7. Wrap-Up and Quick Check (5 min)

Say to children	Let's look at our wonder chart. What can we answer now? Then show me: point to the snail's foot. What does a snail need? How does a snail move? What is one danger for a snail?
Teacher notes	Use the quick-check criteria while children finish journals or as they line up. Record Got it / Getting there / Not yet for each outcome and note any hints. Everyone washes hands with soap. Return snails to the tank or to the place outside where they were found.

Checking for Understanding

These checks guide teaching only. They are not grades. Note when a child used a picture card or a hint.

One-on-one quick check

What to look for	Got it	Getting there	Not yet
Child points to and names snail body parts on a picture or live snail.	names and points to all 4 (shell, foot, tentacles/eyes, mouth)	names 2-3, or points correctly when the teacher says the name	names 0-1
Child names things a snail needs to live.	names 2 or more (food/leaves, water/damp, shelter/hiding place)	names 1, or picks 2 correct picture cards when shown	names none or only things snails do not need
Child tells or shows how a snail moves.	mentions the one foot and the slime	mentions either the foot or the slime, or acts out gliding	says it walks with legs or cannot explain
Child names dangers snails face.	names 2 or more dangers	names 1 danger	names none

Observation journal page

What to look for	Got it	Getting there	Not yet
Journal page shows a real observation of the snail.	drawing shows a shell and body, with at least one correct label or one written/dictated observation	drawing is recognizable but has no label or sentence	page does not show the snail

Class Record

Mark each box: G = Got it, T = Getting there, N = Not yet. Add * if a hint was used.

Child	Body parts	Needs	Movement	Dangers	Journal	Notes

Optional Grade 2 Extension

Grade 2 Extension: Snail Life Cycle (15 min)

Separate day. Not part of the core 48 minutes.

Say to children	Here are four snail pictures: eggs, a baby snail, a growing snail, and a grown-up snail. Put them in order. Then tell the story of how a snail grows. Does a snail ever leave its shell?
Teacher notes	Materials: life-cycle picture cards (one set per pair). Pairs order the cards, then share the story. Check each child's order and explanation.

- Got it: correct order and says the shell grows with the snail
- Getting there: correct order with help, or order right but no explanation
- Not yet: cards out of order